‘It’s our diet plan for the next four weeks,’ he said. As we went into the living room, he turned a few pages of the magazine and handed it to me. It had the diet routine for Rekha—one of Bollywood’s most iconic actors.

‘So you want me to follow her diet?’ I asked as I read through the page.

‘We,’ he stressed the word, ‘*we* will be following Rekha’s diet.’

‘What?’ I reacted. ‘Why do you need to diet?’

‘I can’t let my Gunju diet alone,’ he said. ‘Besides, it’ll be good for me to lose some extra kilos as well.’ He then looked at Maa, who had just entered the living room, and continued, ‘. . . And impress your Maa.’ Maa smiled and went into the kitchen.

The diet plan from *Reader’s Digest* was not as strict as the one Papaji had chalked out before. And having someone by my side, eating the same food as me, was quite motivating. Having Papaji accompany me in everything for these four tough weeks was a big help. We ran together, cycled together, ate together, and all of this helped me reach my desired weight. Each week was tougher than the previous one. My runs were timed, my cycling circuits were timed, my push-ups and sit-ups had to reach a minimum count, but together, we made it through these four physically excruciating weeks. The weight loss soon began to reflect on my face as my jawline and cheekbones sharpened. Even Papaji’s weight loss was visible in his loosening uniform. Then the day of the appeal medical board came, and Papaji and I left for Delhi. Maa and Papaji always inculcated in Dada and me a sense of responsibility by sending us everywhere all by ourselves, even when I had left for the hostel. But Papaji decided to accompany me this time.

As much as he tried to hide his nervousness, I could see it on his face. I was equally nervous. Upon reaching Delhi, we reported to the AFCME, where, after the initial documentation, I was sent for a weight check. I had lost eight kilos. I had crossed my first obstacle. But uncertainty still loomed over the second, bigger obstacle—the anthropometry tests. A doctor carefully took various measurements of my body. I could feel beads of sweat break out on my forehead. My height had not changed and I had resigned myself to the fact that I might have to spend the rest of my service years delivering ground-staff duties only. The doctor asked Papaji and me to